The Mortality of Trumpets

by Gregg Moeller



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CHARACTERS: Marvin Reynolds, age twenty-seven
Angel of Death, age unknown

SCENE: Hospital bed

MARVIN lies on bed, eyes closed…ANGEL hovers over the bed, as he chants last rites

DEATH. (*makes sign of the Cross*) …in nomine Patris, Et Filie, et Spiritus sancti…Amen.

ANGEL checks out the situation, then gamely and clumsily tries to pic up MARVIN from the bed, as MARVIN wakes

MARVIN. *groggily* Wha…what are you doing?
DEATH. (*struggling with weight*) Isn't it obvious?
MARVIN. I don't care what is obvious…just what the HELL are you doing?
DEATH. (*still struggling*) I…am….trying…to…take your immortal soul to heaven…if you don't mind…
MARVIN. My…what?
DEATH. (*now REALLY struggling*) Your soul…spirit…your life-force…your immortal animated essense manifested with the Judeo-Christian ethic…(*ANGEL drops MARVIN back on the bed—barely)* Geez, couldn't you skip a meal once in a while? If I wasn't Death, I'd have an aneurism by now.
MARVIN. (*fighting*) Let me go—leave me alone, you lunatic! Help, police! Anybody!
DEATH. No one can hear you…
MARVIN. Some crazy pervert's trying to abduct me…oh, my GOD! Rape! RAPE!
DEATH. Will you SHUT UP> No one can hear you….and don't flatter yourself. You ain't no prize.
MARVIN. Who are you—stay away! I'll bite…(*does so, rather pathetically to the air)*
DEATH. I'm Death, okay? Now, let's go…you're dead, and we're late enough as it is… *(glance at hand, winces*) Now, LOOK at what you did—that fingernail will take an eternity to leah.
MARVIN. (*in disbelief*) Dead?

DEATH. And look at my suit…these wrinkles will never come out. OH! And the seam…

MARVIN. Dead?

DEATH. …they'll never loan me another suit again, at this rate.

MARVIN. Dead?

DEATH. …especially after this. I'll have to go back to burlap—and that chafes me so…

MARVIN. Dead? DEAD?

DEATH. (*aggravated*) Yes…dead. Deceased, shuffled off your mortal coil, defunct, singing with Elvis, gone to eternal slumber, bereft of life—in short, worm food.

MARVIN. (grabs ANGEL, screams) DEAD? How can I be dead?

DEATH. Hold on—I think you dislocated my shoulder.

MARVIN. How…could…I…be…dead?

DEATH. Okay, so maybe I lied. A little. You're not dead—yet. But close.

A long, painful pause—then…

MARVIN. HELP!! Lunatic!!

DEATH. (*wearily, as MARVIN continues screaming*) Please…no one can hear you. Please, stop this…c'mon…All right then…

DEATH takes his index finger and places it under MARVIN's chin and raise him up as if the finger is the sole support of MARVIN's weight—MARVIN reacts with a horrified look and immediately shuts up and is powerless…

DEATH. (*in an unspeakably EVIL voice*) HEED MY WARNINGS OR FEAR MY WRATH, WRETCHED INSECT!

DEATH pulls back finger and MARVIN drops to the floor

MARVIN. (*now nervous and scared*) Wow…that was pretty impressive…Sir.

DEATH. You think so? I did some theater in school. Watch this—

(done in a bad Cockney accent) Oh, Mister Higgins, I don't want no gold and no diamonds—I'm a good girl, I am…

MARVIN. How….

DEATH. (*continues*) The rain in Spain lays mainly in the—

MARVIN. HOW can I be…

DEATH. Dead?

MARVIN. And then not be…

DEATH. Dead? Simple. (*ANGEL takes him gently aside as they talk)*
Your soul is "in transition". It's simple. Your core unit—that's what we call your body—is about to cease operation—die. Therefore, your soul must prepare for the transition to eternity, or heaven, as you know it.

MARVIN. So, I'm not dead…yet?

DEATH. Well, no…

MARVIN. So, go away.

DEATH. Uh, it's not that simple…

MARVIN. If I'm not dead, I don't want to go.

DEATH. You don't understand…

MARVIN. Simple algebra—Not Dead Equals Alive, so by all equations I—

DEATH. (*grabs MARVIN*) You want proof? Fine.

ANGEL pulls MARVIN around back of the bed, and grabs his head and forces him to look at "himself"

DEATH. There you are—dying, with tubes and wires and catheters…LOOK!

MARVIN. (numb) H…h…how?

DEATH. Blood clot—went straight to the brain.

MARVIN. No…no…no…I'm so….

DEATH. You let me no choice. Now, let's go…I hate the smell of these places. All that Lysol.

MARVIN. But...I…I just want….

DEATH. I just hope you followed that old Mom Rule about having on clean underwear at all times…

ANGEL tries to peek under the sheets, as MARVIN pulls back cover

MARVIN. I was in a hurry, all right? What kind of "angel of death" are you, anyway?

DEATH. It's the outfit, isn't it? My voice…what?

MARVIN. Well, you just don't "scare" me. Isn't death supposed to be bony, and dressed in black and…well, scary?

DEATH. You mean, like in the movies? C'mon, now…really.

MARVIN. No, really. I always pictured death that way.

DEATH. All right…have it your way.

ANGEL jumps on the bed, gesturing wildly with snarling evil voice and other bad sound effects attempts

DEATH. I AM DEATH….FEAR ME, PUNY MOR-TAL!

MARVIN. (*cowering*) AAAUGH! No! Not DEATH! PLEASE…no, that won't work…I know it's you.

DEATH. Maybe you need something different—how about…

ANGEL jumps about wildly, making honking noises and giggling incoherently

DEATH. HI, THERE! I'm PERCY, THE DEATH CLOWN! Huh-HA! Honk! Honk! I'm here to escort your soul to Heaven! Ha-ha-HA!

MARVIN. (*unimpressed*) Percy. The death clown.

DEATH. Honk! (*now desperate*) C'mon…work with me on this…wait—I know!

ANGEL circles the table, then crosses over to MARVIN seductively and vampishly, oozing female sensuality

DEATH. Well, hello there, Big Boy. Don't you want to take an eentsy-weentsy little trip with…moi?

MARVIN. (*aroused*) Oh…baby, I…no-no-NO! I still know its YOU in there!

DEATH. (*still vamping*) Sorry…er, I mean, sorry. I'm trying my best…

MARVIN. Don't you know how to DO this?

DEATH. Actually…I'm filling in for a friend. I'm usually in charge of a vital Heavenly duty on my regular tours. Really important. Yep.

MARVIN. Which is…?

DEATH. (*meekly*) I handle prayers from amateur bowlers trying to nail seven-ten splits.

MARVIN. Well, I'm not going. With you.

DEATH. Aw, c'mon…help me out here.

MARVIN. (*angry*) Leave me alone!

MARVIN returns to "his" bedside

MARVIN. Dead…I didn't feel anything…

DEATH. Well, you aren't dead, technically. You are actually pretty lucky, for being in an irreversible coma and everything…

MARVIN. (*outraged*) Lucky? Me, LUCKY? I'm dying, I get Earl Anthony's guardian angel, and…I got no trumpets.

DEATH. Pardon?

MARVIN. Death is supposed to be a grand, majestic show, with bright lights, heavenly choirs, the pealing of bells, and long-dead family members calling me forward….and trumpets. Trumpets shaking the earth with their cries, welcoming me to Paradise..

DEATH. I can play the spoons pretty good, if that will—

MARVIN. My life stunk enough—now my death has to be just as bad?

DEATH. Sorry…

MARVIN. That takes it. No trumpets, no me. I'm not going.

DEATH. You got to.

MARVIN. (*with increasing self-delusion*) I'll heal up. They'll operate.

DEATH. The damage was too great.

MARVIN. Someone will create a cure while I'm—sleeping…yeah, sleeping…

DEATH. You're not listening…

MARVIN. And when I wake up, I'll laugh and tell everyone about you, and then I'll get up,and get married to a nice gal and own my own house…

DEATH. You're on life support…

MARVIN. (*faltering*) And then I'll go to parties and see my children play football and…and….I'll…

DEATH. (*grabs him, and confronts him*) You're DYING! Can't you see that? The longer you hold onto life, the less it'll be worth!

MARVIN. (*near tears*) I'll go to church more…I'll—

DEATH. You can't turn back!

MARVIN. (*breaks free from ANGEL, with great emotion)* I CAN'T DIE! Not like this…a blood clot?

(*MARVIN collapses at "his" bedside, sobbing loudly)*

MARVIN. Why couldn't it be something cool…

DEATH. Cool?

MARVIN. You know—a "movie death"…me gasping for air….cool.

DEATH. I don't follow.

MARVIN. C'mon…where I grab my chest… (*and he does so, very overdramatically*) stagger around the room… (*again, does so with a bit too much elan*) maybe a had gesture or two, coupled with a look of painful realization… (*does same*) a brief final word for my beloved ones to treasure: "Omlet, du Fromage!" and I drop lifelessly to the floor…(*drops*) Look—rigor mortis! (*stiffens a bit too realistically*)

DEATH. You're sick. You want to see "real" death? Here—sit.

DEATH moves a chair stage center, and MARVIN sits. DEATH proceeds to run a "slide show" of death scenes towards the audience, as of the screen is right in front of them, and makes clicking noises while operating a projector controller, as if he running a slide projector

MARVIN. (*following ANGEL's first click, grimacing at the horrible "images" on the "screen")* Ugh…. (*second click*) Yeech… (*third click—reacts with horror*) Ewww…the whole trombone?

DEATH stops slide show, puts away 'screen'

MARVIN. I just want my death to be memorable….like Fonzie's.

DEATH. Fonzie didn't die. He WAS in a coma once, after he met Pinky Tuscadero.

MARVIN. No, no…Richie was in the coma, after he---oh, my God, here I am, arguing trivia with Beer Frame and I AM DYING!

DEATH. Listen…listen to me. I understand that you don't want to die. All I want you to do is accept it. You will gain nothing by fighting for a life not fit to live. Image means nothing now. Death is not a contest!

MARVIN. (*frustrated and angry*) But…but…why like this? No drama…no final words. All alone. All this time and effort for living and what does it get me? Not even trumpets…is that all I'm worth to you, God? Silence? That's all?

MARVIN begins weeping, with head in hands. DEATH watches MARVIN with sympathy, then looks up and silently coaxes God, with barely audible easily visible please, of "Come on", and "Just once, for him" and "please", etc.

Then, slowly but excitedly, MARVIN is distracted by something detectable only to him—the sound of trumpets.

MARVIN. (*silently, but building with excitement*) Trumpets…trumpets...do you hear them?

As MARVIN reacts to the 'trumpets', DEATH mimes a grateful "thank you" heavenward, as well as a wink and an "OK" sign

DEATH. Yes, I do…Beautiful, aren't they?

DEATH slowly begins to lead a faltering MARVIN back to his bed, as he is now dying

MARVIN. Trumpets…feel the floor move, man! Wow… (*weakens*) Oh, my…

DEATH. Just relax, and let the trumpets call you.

MARVIN. Wow…trumpets…I'm cold—I'm so cold…what's—

DEATH. (*calms and soothes him*) Just focus—focus on your trumpets.

MARVIN. (*with labored breathing and increased spasms of pain, as he is indeed dying*) What—what's happ…(*MARVIN, in his agony, looks at DEATH, and realizes he is indeed dying—DEATH smiles, nod and comforts him*) Trumpets, man…aren't they incredible?

DEATH. Just for you. Special request.

MARVIN. Cool.

DEATH. Relax, now….it will be over soon…it will take but a moment, a twinkling of an eye…

MARVIN. "…and the last trump, of the trumpets will sound…"

ANGEL gently sweeps his hand over MARVIN's face, and MARVIN's eyes close, and his breathing stops—he is at peace

DEATH. And we will be changed.